Betrayer, Judas Iscariot

By Richard Exley

INTRODUCTION

Who knows what makes a man like Judas do what he did. Of this we can be certain, he did not follow Jesus in order to betray him. Like the other disciples he left everything-family, friends, career-to serve Him. Along the way something happened, some little thing most likely, that poisoned his soul and made him susceptible to Satan's snare.

He came to Jesus with high expectations and when his expectations were not realized his disappointment soon turned to disillusionment. His bitterness of soul caused him to make a pact with the devil. "Then Satan entered Judas, called Iscariot, one of the Twelve. And Judas went to the chief priests and the officers of the temple guard and discussed with them how he might betray Jesus.

From the mind and soul of the Betrayer, Judas Iscariot by Richard Exley.

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Having delivered Jesus into the hands of the chief priests as per our agreement, I now watch as the temple guards bind his hands and prepare to lead him away. I should have a sense of triumph, or at least some feeling of accomplishment, but I don't. Instead I feel strangely empty. Not guilty, just unfulfilled.

Against my will my mind returns to an earlier time when hope was as bright as the summer sun. In those days I believed Jesus could do anything. He had a way of speaking unlike anyone I had ever heard. When he talked about the Father, or the kingdom, my heart fairly leaped within me. He made it all seem so immediate, so real. There were even moments when I could almost believe that he was the chosen One.

For all his gifts, Jesus was incredibly naive. A politically astute person would have built on his popularity and seized the moment. But not Jesus! There were several times, especially during the early months of his ministry, when the masses were determined to make him a king. What did he do? He went into hiding, disappearing for weeks at a time. We tried to reason with him, but to no avail.

With an effort I dismiss all thoughts of what might have been. It is too late for that and I will not torment myself with idle speculation now. I have made my decision, cast my lot with the elders and chief priests. Let others judge me if they will, I know I did the only sensible thing under the circumstances, difficult though it was.

A surly guard now prods Jesus with the butt of his spear and we move out. Leaving Gethsemane we enter Jerusalem. As we wind our way through the dark streets, one of the temple guards positions himself at my shoulder. "What's he really like?" he asks, nodding his head in the direction of Jesus. Being in no mood for small talk I ignore him, hoping he will go away. Unfortunately, he seems oblivious to my reticence, and after awhile he tries again. "I've heard rumors about miracles and such like," he says. "What do you know about that?"

"Little enough," I say. Though if the truth be known the miracles of Jesus are too numerous to be numbered. His disappointment is plain enough, but I am not about to get into this. The memories are still too fresh, and capable of invoking the very feelings from which I have tried so hard to distance myself. Talking about it can serve no good purpose.

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There are no lanterns or torches, and an order is given to maintain absolute silence. According to the captain, it is imperative we attract no attention as we make our way toward the house of the high priest. All of this secrecy can only mean one thing-they intend to try Jesus tonight. Although secret trials are strictly forbidden by our law, it now seems obvious that this is exactly what Caiaphas has in mind. It makes sense. Who knows what might happen if the multitudes were to awaken in the morning and find Jesus in the hands of the elders and the chief priests. But, if the trial is finished before daybreak and Jesus is already in the custody of the Romans, the Sanhedrin will have little or nothing to fear.

Arriving at the house of the high priest, Jesus is immediately taken into a large semicircular room where the Sanhedrin is already in session. A movement in the dark catches my eye, and I watch as John moves toward the outer door of the courtyard. Furtively he glances over his shoulder before opening the door. A large man emerges from the shadows beyond the wall and quickly steps inside. For an instant he is framed in the light. With a start I realize that it is Simon Peter. What is he doing here? Surely he can't be crazy enough to try to rescue Jesus. Such an attempt would be ludicrous. Still, I cannot help thinking it is just the kind of thing Peter might attempt. One thing is certain, I dare not show my face while he is around.

Moving deeper into the shadows I turn my attention back to the ecclesiastical trial. In dismay I watch as our carefully laid plans seem to unravel before my eyes. Witness after witness is heard, yet the Sanhedrin can find no evidence with

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which to condemn Jesus. Finally Caiaphas takes matters into his own hands. Rising from his elevated seat he addresses Jesus in his most judicial manner. "I charge you under oath by the living God: Tell us if you are the Christ, the Son of God."

Instantly the atmosphere in the room changes. The weariness and frustration of the long night give way to a sudden tension. Around the room the elders and chief priests lean forward. They sense Jesus himself may provide the condemning evidence they have not been able to produce. Caiaphas remains standing, towering over Jesus, willing him to incriminate himself. Only Jesus seems unmoved by the drama of the moment. Yet he too is different, energized somehow. It is a transformation I have seen before. I saw it first when he commanded the storm to cease, and again when he raised the widow's son from the dead. Still, I have never sensed such transcendent authority, not even when he commanded Lazarus to come forth.

"Yes, it is as you say," Jesus replies, his voice clear and distinct. "But I say to all of you: In the future you will see the Son of Man sitting at the right hand of the Mighty One and coming on the clouds of heaven."

In an instant the high priest gnashes his teeth and tears his robe, nearly beside himself with self-righteous rage. "He has spoken blasphemy!" he screams. "Why do we need any more witnesses?"

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With one voice the Sanhedrin answers, "He is worthy of death!" Suddenly the hatred and jealousy they have harbored these many months erupt. Rushing forward, they deposit huge wads of foul spittle full in his face. Others strike him with their fists, screaming, "Prophesy to us, Christ. Who hit you?"
My reaction is different. It is not blasphemy I have heard, but prophetic revelation, and now the magnitude of what I have done hits me for the first time. It is not an impostor I have delivered into the hands of the religious authorities, but the Messiah. I have betrayed the chosen One of God!

In stunned disbelief I watch from the shadows as the guards bind Jesus and prepare to deliver him to Pontius Pilate. Although his beard is stiff with spittle and his face bruised and bleeding, there is about him sense of dignity that dwarfs his accusers.

"Wait!" I scream leaping to my feet and rushing toward the high priest. For just a moment Our eyes meet. In his there is a flicker of recognition, then he turns away in disgust. In that instant I see my condemnation written in his face. He has played me for a fool. Now that I am of no further use to him, I am of no more value than a leper in the streets, or a gentile.

"Wait!" I scream again, trying to force my way through the temple guards who block my way. Reaching inside my garment I grab the bag of silver coins and thrust it toward the priests. "Take these," I plead. "Let Jesus go. He has done nothing worthy of death." Ignoring the coins, they restrain me as Jesus is led away. When finally I am released I rush desperately from priest to priest begging, "Help me

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for I have sinned. I have betrayed innocent blood." It is no use. They will not hear me. My desperate pleas full on deaf ears.

Finally one of them says with a sneer, "What is that to us? That's your responsibility." His words are like a dagger plunged into my heart. Grabbing the silver coins, I hurl them at their feet before rushing into the street. Now the awful weight of my treachery descends upon me afresh and I stagger beneath the burden of my sin. It isn't just what I did-unspeakable though it was-but what I am. To my everlasting shame I discover that the deed and I are one!

I am driven to flee, to run away, but where can I go? The thing I cannot escape, the thing I cannot bear, is myself So this is hell, I think, to live forever with what I have done. Stumbling through the streets the words of Jesus return to haunt me. "The Son of Man will go just as it has been written about him. But woe to that man who betrays the Son of Man. It would be better for him if he had not been born."

I curse the day of my birth. I curse the day I heard the name of Jesus. I curse the high priest and the Roman governor. I curse my own life. In absolute despair I scream, "I am damned! I am damned!" After a long time I find myself on the side of a steep hill overlooking a deep ravine. A rope is in my hand and on one end I have fashioned a hangman's noose. In a trancelike state, I loop the other end over a branch, being careful to place it as far out as I can reach. When it is securely tied I drop the noose over my head and draw it tight around my neck. Closing my eyes I try to remember my mother's face but I cannot. Instead his eyes stare at me, not

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in anger, but with a wounded love. The way he looked at me when I kissed him in Gethsemane. That's what I cannot bear. Not his anger, but his love. Even now he seems to be calling to me.

I am sobbing now. Weeping like a motherless child, but it is no use. Tears cannot save me. It is too late. Too late. Regardless of what others may think, I know I did not consciously choose to become what I am. It was a subtle process and who can say what small act opened the door to the evil within? But once that door was open, it was impossible to close it again and now I must pay for what I have done.

With all my strength I scream, "I have sinned. I have betrayed the innocent blood of my Lord." Then I leap . . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

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